a dark blur on the very edge of the horizon. A few paces beyond the last market garden stood a tavern, a big tavern, which had always aroused in him a feeling of aversion, even of fear, when he walked by it with his father. There was always a crowd there, always shouting, laughter and abuse, hideous hoarse singing and often fight-ing. Drunken and horrible-looking figures were hanging about the tavern. He used to cling close to his father, trem-bling all over when he met them. Near the tavern the road became a dusty track, the dust of which was always black. It was a winding road, and about a hundred paces further on, it turned to the right to the graveyard. In the middle of the graveyard stood a stone church with a green cupola where he used to go to mass two or three times a year with his father and mother, when a service was held in memory of his grandmother, who had long been dead, and whom he had never seen. On these occasions they used to take on a white dish tied up in a table napkin a special sort of rice pudding with raisins stuck in it in the shape of a cross. He loved that church, the old-fashioned, unadorned ikons and the old priest with the shaking head. Near his grandmoth-

er's grave, which was marked by a stone, was the little grave of his younger brother who had died at six months old. He did not remember him at all, but he had been told about his little brother, and whenever he visited the graveyard he used religiously and reverently to cross himself and to bow down and kiss the little grave. And now he dreamt that he was walking with his father past the tavern on the way to the graveyard; he was holding his father's hand and looking with dread at the tavern. A peculiar circumstance attract-ed his attention: there seemed to be some kind of festivity going on, there were crowds of gaily dressed townspeople, peasant women, their husbands, and riff-raff of all sorts, all singing and all more or less drunk. Near the entrance of the tavern stood a cart, but a strange cart. It was one of those big carts usually drawn by heavy cart-horses and laden with casks of wine

or other heavy goods. He always liked look-ing at those great cart-horses, with their long manes, thick legs, and slow even pace, drawing along a perfect mountain with no appearance of effort, as though it were easier going with a load than without it. But now, strange to say, in the shafts of such a cart he saw a thin little sorrel beast, one of those peasants' nags which he had often seen straining their utmost under a heavy load of wood or hay, especially when the wheels were stuck in the mud or in a rut. And the peas-ants would beat them so cruelly, sometimes even about the nose and eyes, and he felt so sorry, so sorry for them that he almost cried, and his mother always used to take him away from the window. All of a sudden there was a great uproar of shouting, singing and the balalaïka, and from the

tavern a number of big and very drunken peasants came out, wearing red and blue shirts and coats thrown over their shoulders.

'Get in, get in!' shouted one of them, a young thick-necked peasant with a fleshy face red as a carrot. 'I'll take you all, get in!'

But at once there was an outbreak of laughter and excla-mations in the crowd.

'Take us all with a beast like that!'

'Why, Mikolka, are you crazy to put a nag like that in such a cart?'

'And this mare is twenty if she is a day, mates!'

'Get in, I'll take you all,' Mikolka shouted again, leaping first into the cart, seizing the reins and standing straight up in front. 'The bay has gone with Matvey,' he shouted from the cart—'and this brute, mates, is just breaking my heart, I feel as if I could kill her. She's just eating her head off. Get in, I tell you! I'll make her gallop! She'll gallop!' and he picked up the whip, preparing himself with relish to flog the little mare.

'Get in! Come along!' The crowd laughed. 'D'you hear, she'll gallop!'

‘Gallop indeed! She has not had a gallop in her for the last ten years!’

‘She’ll jog along!’

‘Don’t you mind her, mates, bring a whip each of you, get ready!’

‘All right! Give it to her!’

They all clambered into Mikolka’s cart, laughing and

making jokes. Six men got in and there was still room for more. They hauled in a fat, rosy-cheeked woman. She was dressed in red cotton, in a pointed, beaded headdress and thick leather shoes; she was cracking nuts and laughing. The crowd round them was laughing too and indeed, how could they help laughing? That wretched nag was to drag all the cartload of them at a gallop! Two young fellows in the cart were just getting whips ready to help Mikolka. With the cry of ‘now,’ the mare tugged with all her might, but far from galloping, could scarcely move forward; she struggled with her legs, gasping and shrinking from the blows of the three whips which were showered upon her like hail. The laugh-ter in the cart and in the crowd was redoubled, but Mikolka flew into a rage and furiously thrashed the mare, as though he supposed she really could gallop.

‘Let me get in, too, mates,’ shouted a young man in the crowd whose appetite was aroused.

‘Get in, all get in,’ cried Mikolka, ‘she will draw you all. I’ll beat her to death!’ And he thrashed and thrashed at the mare, beside himself with fury.

‘Father, father,’ he cried, ‘father, what are they doing? Fa-ther, they are beating the poor horse!’

‘Come along, come along!’ said his father. ‘They are drunken and foolish, they are in fun; come away, don’t look!’ and he tried to draw him away, but he tore himself away from his hand, and, beside himself

with horror, ran to the horse. The poor beast was in a bad way. She was gasping, standing still, then tugging again and almost falling.

‘Beat her to death,’ cried Mikolka, ‘it’s come to that. I’ll

do for her!’

‘What are you about, are you a Christian, you devil?’ shouted an old man in the crowd.

‘Did anyone ever see the like? A wretched nag like that pulling such a cartload,’ said another.

‘You’ll kill her,’ shouted the third.

‘Don’t meddle! It’s my property, I’ll do what I choose. Get in, more of you! Get in, all of you! I will have her go at a gal-lop! …’

All at once laughter broke into a roar and covered every-thing: the mare, roused by the shower of blows, began feebly kicking. Even the old man could not help smiling. To think of a wretched little beast like that trying to kick!

Two lads in the crowd snatched up whips and ran to the mare to beat her about the ribs. One ran each side.

‘Hit her in the face, in the eyes, in the eyes,’ cried Mikol-ka.

‘Give us a song, mates,’ shouted someone in the cart and everyone in the cart joined in a riotous song, jingling a tam-bourine and whistling. The woman went on cracking nuts and laughing.

… He ran beside the mare, ran in front of her, saw her being whipped across the eyes, right in the eyes! He was crying, he felt choking, his tears were streaming. One of the men gave him a cut with the whip across the face, he did not feel it. Wringing his hands and screaming, he rushed up to the grey-headed old man with the grey beard, who was

shaking his head in disapproval. One woman seized him by the hand and would have taken him away, but he tore him-

self from her and ran back to the mare. She was almost at the last gasp, but began kicking once more.

‘I’ll teach you to kick,’ Mikolka shouted ferociously. He threw down the whip, bent forward and picked up from the bottom of the cart a long, thick shaft, he took hold of one end with both hands and with an effort brandished it over the mare.

‘He’ll crush her,’ was shouted round him. ‘He’ll kill her!’ ‘It’s my property,’ shouted Mikolka and brought the shaft

down with a swinging blow. There was a sound of a heavy thud.

‘Thrash her, thrash her! Why have you stopped?’ shouted voices in the crowd.

And Mikolka swung the shaft a second time and it fell a second time on the spine of the luckless mare. She sank back on her haunches, but lurched forward and tugged for-ward with all her force, tugged first on one side and then on the other, trying to move the cart. But the six whips were at-tacking her in all directions, and the shaft was raised again and fell upon her a third time, then a fourth, with heavy measured blows. Mikolka was in a fury that he could not kill her at one blow.

‘She’s a tough one,’ was shouted in the crowd.

‘She’ll fall in a minute, mates, there will soon be an end of her,’ said an admiring spectator in the crowd.

‘Fetch an axe to her! Finish her off,’ shouted a third.

‘I’ll show you! Stand off,’ Mikolka screamed frantical-ly; he threw down the shaft, stooped down in the cart and picked up an iron crowbar. ‘Look out,’ he shouted, and with

all his might he dealt a stunning blow at the poor mare. The blow fell; the mare staggered, sank back, tried to pull, but the bar fell again with a swinging blow on her back and she fell on the ground like a log.

‘Finish her off,’ shouted Mikolka and he leapt beside him-self, out of the cart. Several young men, also flushed with drink, seized anything they could come across—whips, sticks, poles, and ran to the dying mare. Mikolka stood on one side and began dealing random blows with the crow-bar. The mare stretched out her head, drew a long breath and died.

‘You butchered her,’ someone shouted in the crowd. ‘Why wouldn’t she gallop then?’

‘My property!’ shouted Mikolka, with bloodshot eyes, brandishing the bar in his hands. He stood as though re-gretting that he had nothing more to beat.

‘No mistake about it, you are not a Christian,’ many voic-es were shouting in the crowd.

But the poor boy, beside himself, made his way, scream-ing, through the crowd to the sorrel nag, put his arms round her bleeding dead head and kissed it, kissed the eyes and kissed the lips…. Then he jumped up and flew in a frenzy with his little fists out at Mikolka. At that instant his father, who had been running after him, snatched him up and car-ried him out of the crowd.

‘Come along, come! Let us go home,’ he said to him. ‘Father! Why did they … kill … the poor horse!’ he

sobbed, but his voice broke and the words came in shrieks from his panting chest.

‘They are drunk…. They are brutal … it’s not our busi-ness!’ said his father. He put his arms round his father but he felt choked, choked. He tried to draw a breath, to cry out—and woke up.

He waked up, gasping for breath, his hair soaked with perspiration, and stood up in terror.

‘Thank God, that was only a dream,’ he said, sitting down under a tree and drawing deep breaths. ‘But what is it? Is it some fever coming on? Such a hideous dream!’

He felt utterly broken: darkness and confusion were in his soul. He rested his elbows on his knees and leaned his head on his hands.

‘Good God!’ he cried, ‘can it be, can it be, that I shall re-ally take an axe, that I shall strike her on the head, split her skull open … that I shall tread in the sticky warm blood, break the lock, steal and tremble; hide, all spattered in the blood … with the axe…. Good God, can it be?’

He was shaking like a leaf as he said this.

‘But why am I going on like this?’ he continued, sitting up again, as it were in profound amazement. ‘I knew that I could never bring myself to it, so what have I been tortur-ing myself for till now? Yesterday, yesterday, when I went to make that … experiment yesterday I realised complete-ly that I could never bear to do it…. Why am I going over it again, then? Why am I hesitating? As I came down the stairs yesterday, I said myself that it was base, loathsome, vile, vile … the very thought of it made me feel sick and filled me with horror.

‘No, I couldn’t do it, I couldn’t do it! Granted, granted that

there is no flaw in all that reasoning, that all that I have con-cluded this last month is clear as day, true as arithmetic…. My God! Anyway I couldn’t bring myself to it! I couldn’t do it, I couldn’t do it! Why, why then am I still … ?’

He rose to his feet, looked round in wonder as though surprised at finding himself in this place, and went towards the bridge. He was pale, his eyes glowed, he was exhausted in every limb, but he seemed suddenly to breathe more easi-ly. He felt he had cast off that fearful burden that had so long been weighing upon him, and all at once there was a sense of relief and peace in his soul. 'Lord,' he prayed, 'show me my path—I renounce that accursed … dream of mine.'

Crossing the bridge, he gazed quietly and calmly at the Neva, at the glowing red sun setting in the glowing sky. In spite of his weakness he was not conscious of fatigue. It was as though an abscess that had been forming for a month past in his heart had suddenly broken. Freedom, freedom! He was free from that spell, that sorcery, that obsession!

Later on, when he recalled that time and all that hap-pened to him during those days, minute by minute, point by point, he was superstitiously impressed by one circum-stance, which, though in itself not very exceptional, always seemed to him afterwards the predestined turning-point of his fate. He could never understand and explain to himself why, when he was tired and worn out, when it would have been more convenient for him to go home by the shortest and most direct way, he had returned by the Hay Market where he had no need to go. It was obviously and quite un-necessarily out of his way, though not much so. It is true that

it happened to him dozens of times to return home without noticing what streets he passed through. But why, he was always asking himself, why had such an important, such a decisive and at the same time such an absolutely chance meeting happened in the Hay Market (where he had more-over no reason to go) at the very hour, the very minute of his life when he was just in the very mood and in the very circumstances in which that meeting was able to exert the gravest and most decisive

influence on his whole destiny? As though it had been lying in wait for him on purpose!

It was about nine o'clock when he crossed the Hay Mar-ket. At the tables and the barrows, at the booths and the shops, all the market people were closing their establish-ments or clearing away and packing up their wares and, like their customers, were going home. Rag pickers and coster-mongers of all kinds were crowding round the taverns in the dirty and stinking courtyards of the Hay Market. Ras-kolnikov particularly liked this place and the neighbouring alleys, when he wandered aimlessly in the streets. Here his rags did not attract contemptuous attention, and one could walk about in any attire without scandalising people. At the corner of an alley a huckster and his wife had two tables set out with tapes, thread, cotton handkerchiefs, etc. They, too, had got up to go home, but were lingering in conver-sation with a friend, who had just come up to them. This friend was Lizaveta Ivanovna, or, as everyone called her, Lizaveta, the younger sister of the old pawnbroker, Alyona Ivanovna, whom Raskolnikov had visited the previous day to pawn his watch and make his experiment…. He already

knew all about Lizaveta and she knew him a little too. She was a single woman of about thirty-five, tall, clumsy, timid, submissive and almost idiotic. She was a complete slave and went in fear and trembling of her sister, who made her work day and night, and even beat her. She was standing with a bundle before the huckster and his wife, listening earnestly and doubtfully. They were talking of something with spe-cial warmth. The moment Raskolnikov caught sight of her, he was overcome by a strange sensation as it were of intense astonishment, though there was nothing astonishing about this meeting.

‘You could make up your mind for yourself, Lizaveta Ivanovna,’ the huckster was saying aloud. ‘Come round to-morrow about seven. They will be here too.’

‘To-morrow?’ said Lizaveta slowly and thoughtfully, as though unable to make up her mind.

‘Upon my word, what a fright you are in of Alyona Iva-novna,’ gabbled the huckster’s wife, a lively little woman. ‘I look at you, you are like some little babe. And she is not your own sister either-nothing but a step-sister and what a hand she keeps over you!’

‘But this time don’t say a word to Alyona Ivanovna,’ her husband interrupted; ‘that’s my advice, but come round to us without asking. It will be worth your while. Later on your sister herself may have a notion.’

‘Am I to come?’

‘About seven o’clock to-morrow. And they will be here. You will be able to decide for yourself.’

‘And we’ll have a cup of tea,’ added his wife.

‘All right, I’ll come,’ said Lizaveta, still pondering, and she began slowly moving away.

Raskolnikov had just passed and heard no more. He passed softly, unnoticed, trying not to miss a word. His first amazement was followed by a thrill of horror, like a shiver running down his spine. He had learnt, he had sud-denly quite unexpectedly learnt, that the next day at seven o’clock Lizaveta, the old woman’s sister and only compan-ion, would be away from home and that therefore at seven o’clock precisely the old woman would be left alone.

He was only a few steps from his lodging. He went in like a man condemned to death. He thought of nothing and was incapable of

thinking; but he felt suddenly in his whole be-ing that he had no more freedom of thought, no will, and that everything was suddenly and irrevocably decided.

Certainly, if he had to wait whole years for a suitable opportunity, he could not reckon on a more certain step towards the success of the plan than that which had just presented itself. In any case, it would have been dificult to find out beforehand and with certainty, with greater exact-ness and less risk, and without dangerous inquiries and investigations, that next day at a certain time an old wom-an, on whose life an attempt was contemplated, would be at home and entirely alone.

Chapter VI

Later on Raskolnikov happened to find out why the huck-ster and his wife had invited Lizaveta. It was a very

ordinary matter and there was nothing exceptional about it. A family who had come to the town and been reduced to poverty were selling their household goods and clothes, all women's things. As the things would have fetched little in the market, they were looking for a dealer. This was Lizave-ta's business. She undertook such jobs and was frequently employed, as she was very honest and always fixed a fair price and stuck to it. She spoke as a rule little and, as we have said already, she was very submissive and timid.

But Raskolnikov had become superstitious of late. The traces of superstition remained in him long after, and were almost ineradicable. And in all this he was always after-wards disposed to see something

strange and mysterious, as it were, the presence of some peculiar influences and co-incidences. In the previous winter a student he knew called Pokorev, who had left for Harkov, had chanced in conver-sation to give him the address of Alyona Ivanovna, the old pawnbroker, in case he might want to pawn anything. For a long while he did not go to her, for he had lessons and managed to get along somehow. Six weeks ago he had re-membered the address; he had two articles that could be pawned: his father's old silver watch and a little gold ring

with three red stones, a present from his sister at parting. He decided to take the ring. When he found the old woman he had felt an insurmountable repulsion for her at the first glance, though he knew nothing special about her. He got two roubles from her and went into a miserable little tavern on his way home. He asked for tea, sat down and sank into deep thought. A strange idea was pecking at his brain like a chicken in the egg, and very, very much absorbed him.

Almost beside him at the next table there was sitting a student, whom he did not know and had never seen, and with him a young oficer. They had played a game of bil-liards and began drinking tea. All at once he heard the student mention to the oficer the pawnbroker Alyona Ivanovna and give him her address. This of itself seemed strange to Raskolnikov; he had just come from her and here at once he heard her name. Of course it was a chance, but he could not shake off a very extraordinary impression, and here someone seemed to be speaking expressly for him; the student began telling his friend various details about Aly-ona Ivanovna.

'She is first-rate,' he said. 'You can always get money from her. She is as rich as a Jew, she can give you five thousand roubles at a time and she is not above taking a pledge for a rouble. Lots of our fellows have had dealings with her. But she is an awful old harpy….'

And he began describing how spiteful and uncertain she was, how if you were only a day late with your interest the pledge was lost; how she gave a quarter of the value of an ar-ticle and took five and even seven percent a month on it and

so on. The student chattered on, saying that she had a sister Lizaveta, whom the wretched little creature was continually beating, and kept in complete bondage like a small child, though Lizaveta was at least six feet high.

'There's a phenomenon for you,' cried the student and he laughed.

They began talking about Lizaveta. The student spoke about her with a peculiar relish and was continually laugh-ing and the oficer listened with great interest and asked him to send Lizaveta to do some mending for him. Raskol-nikov did not miss a word and learned everything about her. Lizaveta was younger than the old woman and was her half-sister, being the child of a different mother. She was thirty-five. She worked day and night for her sister, and besides doing the cooking and the washing, she did sew-ing and worked as a charwoman and gave her sister all she earned. She did not dare to accept an order or job of any kind without her sister's permission. The old woman had already made her will, and Lizaveta knew of it, and by this will she would not get a farthing; nothing but the movables, chairs and so on; all the money was left to a monastery in the province of N——, that prayers might be said for her in perpetuity. Lizaveta was of lower rank than her sister, un-married and awfully uncouth in appearance, remarkably tall with long feet that looked as if they were bent outwards. She always wore battered goatskin shoes, and was clean in her person. What the student expressed most surprise and amusement about was the fact that Lizaveta was continu-ally with child.

‘But you say she is hideous?’ observed the oficer.

‘Yes, she is so dark-skinned and looks like a soldier dressed up, but you know she is not at all hideous. She has such a good-natured face and eyes. Strikingly so. And the proof of it is that lots of people are attracted by her. She is such a soft, gentle creature, ready to put up with anything, always willing, willing to do anything. And her smile is re-ally very sweet.’

‘You seem to find her attractive yourself,’ laughed the of-ficer.

‘From her queerness. No, I’ll tell you what. I could kill that damned old woman and make off with her money, I as-sure you, without the faintest conscience-prick,’ the student added with warmth. The oficer laughed again while Ras-kolnikov shuddered. How strange it was!

‘Listen, I want to ask you a serious question,’ the student said hotly. ‘I was joking of course, but look here; on one side we have a stupid, senseless, worthless, spiteful, ailing, hor-rid old woman, not simply useless but doing actual mischief, who has not an idea what she is living for herself, and who will die in a day or two in any case. You understand? You understand?’

‘Yes, yes, I understand,’ answered the oficer, watching his excited companion attentively.

‘Well, listen then. On the other side, fresh young lives thrown away for want of help and by thousands, on every side! A hundred thousand good deeds could be done and helped, on that old woman’s money which will be buried in a monastery! Hundreds, thousands perhaps, might be set

on the right path; dozens of families saved from destitu-tion, from ruin, from vice, from the Lock hospitals—and all with her money. Kill her,

take her money and with the help of it devote oneself to the service of humanity and the good of all. What do you think, would not one tiny crime be wiped out by thousands of good deeds? For one life thousands would be saved from corruption and decay. One death, and a hundred lives in exchange—it's simple arith-metic! Besides, what value has the life of that sickly, stupid, ill-natured old woman in the balance of existence! No more than the life of a louse, of a black-beetle, less in fact because the old woman is doing harm. She is wearing out the lives of others; the other day she bit Lizaveta's finger out of spite; it almost had to be amputated.'

'Of course she does not deserve to live,' remarked the of-ficer, 'but there it is, it's nature.'

'Oh, well, brother, but we have to correct and direct na-ture, and, but for that, we should drown in an ocean of prejudice. But for that, there would never have been a single great man. They talk of duty, conscience—I don't want to say anything against duty and conscience; —but the point is, what do we mean by them. Stay, I have another question to ask you. Listen!'

'No, you stay, I'll ask you a question. Listen!' 'Well?'

'You are talking and speechifying away, but tell me, would you kill the old woman yourself?'

'Of course not! I was only arguing the justice of it…. It's nothing to do with me….'

'But I think, if you would not do it yourself, there's no justice about it…. Let us have another game.'

Raskolnikov was violently agitated. Of course, it was all ordinary youthful talk and thought, such as he had often heard before in different forms and on different themes. But why had he happened to hear such a discussion and such ideas at the very moment when his

own brain was just con-ceiving … the very same ideas? And why, just at the moment when he had brought away the embryo of his idea from the old woman had he dropped at once upon a conversation about her? This coincidence always seemed strange to him. This trivial talk in a tavern had an immense influence on him in his later action; as though there had really been in it something preordained, some guiding hint….

*****

On returning from the Hay Market he flung himself on the sofa and sat for a whole hour without stirring. Mean-while it got dark; he had no candle and, indeed, it did not occur to him to light up. He could never recollect whether he had been thinking about anything at that time. At last he was conscious of his former fever and shivering, and he realised with relief that he could lie down on the sofa. Soon heavy, leaden sleep came over him, as it were crushing him.

He slept an extraordinarily long time and without dream-ing. Nastasya, coming into his room at ten o'clock the next morning, had dificulty in rousing him. She brought him in tea and bread. The tea was again the second brew and again in her own tea-pot.

'My goodness, how he sleeps!' she cried indignantly. 'And

he is always asleep.'

He got up with an effort. His head ached, he stood up, took a turn in his garret and sank back on the sofa again.

'Going to sleep again,' cried Nastasya. 'Are you ill, eh?' He made no reply.

'Do you want some tea?'

'Afterwards,' he said with an effort, closing his eyes again and turning to the wall.

Nastasya stood over him.

‘Perhaps he really is ill,’ she said, turned and went out. She came in again at two o’clock with soup. He was lying as before. The tea stood untouched. Nastasya felt positively of-fended and began wrathfully rousing him.

‘Why are you lying like a log?’ she shouted, looking at him with repulsion.

He got up, and sat down again, but said nothing and stared at the floor.

‘Are you ill or not?’ asked Nastasya and again received no answer. ‘You’d better go out and get a breath of air,’ she said after a pause. ‘Will you eat it or not?’

‘Afterwards,’ he said weakly. ‘You can go.’ And he motioned her out.

She remained a little longer, looked at him with compas-sion and went out.

A few minutes afterwards, he raised his eyes and looked for a long while at the tea and the soup. Then he took the bread, took up a spoon and began to eat.

He ate a little, three or four spoonfuls, without appetite, as it were mechanically. His head ached less. After his meal

he stretched himself on the sofa again, but now he could not sleep; he lay without stirring, with his face in the pillow. He was haunted by day-dreams and such strange day-dreams; in one, that kept recurring, he fancied that he was in Afri-ca, in Egypt, in some sort of oasis. The caravan was resting, the camels were peacefully lying down; the palms stood all around in a complete circle; all the party were at din-ner. But he was drinking water from a spring which flowed gurgling close by. And it was so cool, it was wonderful, wonderful, blue, cold water running among the parti-co-loured stones and over the clean sand which glistened here and there like gold…. Suddenly he heard a clock

strike. He started, roused himself, raised his head, looked out of the window, and seeing how late it was, suddenly jumped up wide awake as though someone had pulled him off the sofa. He crept on tiptoe to the door, stealthily opened it and be-gan listening on the staircase. His heart beat terribly. But all was quiet on the stairs as if everyone was asleep…. It seemed to him strange and monstrous that he could have slept in such forgetfulness from the previous day and had done nothing, had prepared nothing yet…. And meanwhile perhaps it had struck six. And his drowsiness and stupe-faction were followed by an extraordinary, feverish, as it were distracted haste. But the preparations to be made were few. He concentrated all his energies on thinking of every-thing and forgetting nothing; and his heart kept beating and thumping so that he could hardly breathe. First he had to make a noose and sew it into his overcoat—a work of a moment. He rummaged under his pillow and picked out

amongst the linen stuffed away under it, a worn out, old unwashed shirt. From its rags he tore a long strip, a cou-ple of inches wide and about sixteen inches long. He folded this strip in two, took off his wide, strong summer overcoat of some stout cotton material (his only outer garment) and began sewing the two ends of the rag on the inside, under the left armhole. His hands shook as he sewed, but he did it successfully so that nothing showed outside when he put the coat on again. The needle and thread he had got ready long before and they lay on his table in a piece of paper. As for the noose, it was a very ingenious device of his own; the noose was intended for the axe. It was impossible for him to carry the axe through the street in his hands. And if hidden under his coat he would still have had to support it with his hand, which would have been noticeable. Now he had only to put the head of the axe in the noose, and it would hang quietly under his arm on the inside. Putting his hand in his coat pocket, he could hold the end of the handle all the way, so that it did not swing; and as the coat was

very full, a regu-lar sack in fact, it could not be seen from outside that he was holding something with the hand that was in the pocket. This noose, too, he had designed a fortnight before.

When he had finished with this, he thrust his hand into a little opening between his sofa and the floor, fumbled in the left corner and drew out the pledge which he had got ready long before and hidden there. This pledge was, however, only a smoothly planed piece of wood the size and thick-ness of a silver cigarette case. He picked up this piece of wood in one of his wanderings in a courtyard where there

was some sort of a workshop. Afterwards he had added to the wood a thin smooth piece of iron, which he had also picked up at the same time in the street. Putting the iron which was a little the smaller on the piece of wood, he fas-tened them very firmly, crossing and re-crossing the thread round them; then wrapped them carefully and daintily in clean white paper and tied up the parcel so that it would be very dificult to untie it. This was in order to divert the at-tention of the old woman for a time, while she was trying to undo the knot, and so to gain a moment. The iron strip was added to give weight, so that the woman might not guess the first minute that the ‘thing’ was made of wood. All this had been stored by him beforehand under the sofa. He had only just got the pledge out when he heard someone sud-denly about in the yard.

‘It struck six long ago.’ ‘Long ago! My God!’

He rushed to the door, listened, caught up his hat and began to descend his thirteen steps cautiously, noiselessly, like a cat. He had still the most important thing to do—to steal the axe from the kitchen. That the deed must be done with an axe he had decided long ago. He had also a pocket pruning-knife, but he could not rely on the knife and still less on his own strength, and so resolved finally on the axe. We may note in passing, one peculiarity in regard to all the final resolutions